Why grow your own?

There is something rather satisfying about putting supper on the table and knowing that you grew part of it. You chose the crop, looked after it and picked it when it was ready. That small piece of independence is a good enough reason to begin. And here are a few others:



Grow the things you want to eat

A garden gives you choices that a shopping list does not. You can try a different variety, pick young leaves for lunch or grow something that rarely appears in the shops. I grow artichokes partly because I like them and partly because I can seldom buy them locally. Their value to me is greater than their weight in a basket.

Save money from the start

You can begin growing with a very basic set of tools, and you can save money by making your own compost and reusing materials you already have. Grow the vegetables your household enjoys most. A small bed of salads, picked regularly, can provide plenty of fresh leaves and save you buying them each week.

Enjoy what the season gives you

Home growing brings abundance and gaps, sometimes in the same week. Eating with the seasons brings challenges but it also has its rewards. You will discover, for instance, why our ancestors feasted in the autumn and midwinter - because food is in surplus after the harvest. And why our bodies naturally become more active in the springtime. (Clue: Digging is physical work!)

Begin with one useful patch

You do not need to become self-sufficient, or grow everything in this book. One sunny bed, a few crops and a little attention will teach you more than a winter spent planning the perfect garden. Keep a note of what works, then build on it.

John: Hackriculture introduction; Food Independence; Money-Saving Tips.